



4 Strategies for Building Collaboration

SCRIPT



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4 Strategies for Building Collaboration | Duration 10:42

FULL SCREEN GRAPHIC:

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ANIMATED TITLES:

| INSIGHTS AND STRATEGIES

| 4 Strategies for Building Collaboration

| **Eve Ash** Psychologist &
| **Peter Quarry** Psychology Expert

EVE: Collaboration is being talked about more and more as an essential skill.

PETER: That's right, in fact there was a survey done by the Financial Times that found that the ability to work collaboratively to work with a number of different people, in teams, (SUPER: **Collaboration – one of 5 top skills employers want**) and so on, was actually one of the five top skills that employers are looking for.

00:51

TITLE: **The Benefits of Collaboration**

GRAPHIC BUILDS:

Collaboration

noun

- two or more people working together to produce something

EVE: So let's run through some of the benefits of collaboration.

PETER: Well, collaboration is considered one of the indicators of success for many, many companies.

GRAPHIC BUILDS:

Companies promoting collaboration 5 X more high-performing

In fact, research that studied over 1,000 companies found that those that promoted collaboration in the workplace tended to be about five times more high-performing than those that didn't.

EVE: Wow, well, that's great for the organization, but what about for the individual?

PETER: Well, it's interesting, because individuals who

SUPER BUILDS:

Individuals working collaboratively

- **Less stressed**
- **Happier**
- **More engaged**

work in a collaborative situation tend to be less stressed, happier, and, interestingly, more engaged.

GRAPHIC BUILDS:

People who work collaboratively stick at tasks 64% longer than solitary peers.

Stanford University study

There's been a study for example at Stanford University which found that people who work collaboratively stick at tasks an amazing 64% longer than their solitary peers.

EVE: Let's go through the four strategies for building collaboration.

PETER: Well, first of all, you need to

GRAPHIC BUILDS:

Building Collaboration

- Create a culture of collaboration
- Avoid collaboration killers
- Improve meeting efficiency
- Design collaborative workspaces

create a culture of collaboration. Secondly, avoid the collaboration killers. I think it's important to improve meeting efficiency, and finally, think about designing collaborative workspaces.

2:15

TITLE: **The Collaboration Conversation**

EVE: When we were collaborating on this program, we came up with a very creative way to (SUPER: **Develop a culture of collaboration**) develop a culture for collaboration.

PETER: That's right, because developing that culture is actually quite difficult, but we came up with this technique which we call (SUPER: **The Collaboration Conversation**) the collaboration conversation, and it's basically a series of questions that you can answer and then talk about with other people about how you work, and it really forms the basis for a conversation where you can negotiate the way in which you work, and the way in which you collaborate with each other.

EVE: Let's say you and I decide to work together collaboratively, we could actually use these questions to ask each other.

PETER: That's right, and the first three questions are really about sharing information about how we like to work. So question one is, *'What is my work style?'*

GRAPHIC BUILDS:

The Collaboration Conversation Questions

1. What is my work style?
2. How do I like to communicate?
3. What annoys me about how others work and communicate?
4. What am I willing to do differently or change about how I work?
5. What would I like you to change about how you work?
6. If our collaboration is not working, how will we deal with this?

PETER: So for example, I'm very fussy around time. I like meetings to start on time. I like meetings to end on time. You might tell me ...

EVE: That I like to get things done quickly, and I like a lot of things to be done in a short space of time.

PETER: Correct, so we'll start sharing some information. Second question is, *'How do I like to communicate?'* Now, I tend to like to communicate by phone or face-to-face, in other words, talking, whereas ...

EVE: Sometimes I like to get emails and to get scripts, so that I can actually edit in my own time.

PETER: Now the third question is a really interesting one, and that is, *'What annoys me about how others work and communicate?'*

EVE: So it's not actually what annoys me about you if I'm sitting down to work with you, it's in the past, *'What has annoyed me with other people's behaviors?'*

PETER: Correct. Correct.

- EVE: So that way, we can identify where our similarities are, but also areas of potential difficulty before they've actually happened.
- PETER: That's exactly right. So that allows you then to move on to the next set of three questions. So, question four is, *'What am I willing to do differently or change about how I work?'* So if I've heard that, you know, you like to meet deadlines very, very definitely, I'll say, well, look, generally I don't do that, but I'm willing to do that in this case to make sure that we work well. Question five then kind of piggybacks on the back of that, which is, *'What would I like you to do differently?'* *'What would I like you to change about how you work?'* So it might be, I'd like you to come over to my place 50% of the time, for example. The final question, question six is, *'If our collaboration is not working, how will we deal with this?'*
- EVE: That's such an important one, because if we say now how we're going to deal with the difficulty, there's going to be no tension around it, no angst, and then we'll just have a plan.
- PETER: Or I might just say, well, look, if there is difficulty, talk to me, say *"let's go and have a coffee, and talk."* So look, these questions are really about negotiating, how are we going to work, sharing information about how we tend to work, and making sure that any issue is dealt with early. A very simple, but yet quite effective way to get people (SUPER: **Create a culture of collaboration**) to create that culture of collaboration, whether you're working in teams, in large organizations, or even just one-to-one.

5:41

TITLE: **Avoid the 6 Collaboration Killers**

EVE: There are a number of individual behaviors that can really kill collaboration.

PETER: That's right, the first one is

GRAPHIC BUILDS:

Collaboration Killer

1. Talking more than you're listening
2. Instant judgments & opinions
3. Not acknowledging ideas
4. Punishing honesty
5. Defensively clinging to ideas
6. Not experimenting

Skills Required

- Listen
- Suspend judgment, find facts
- Encourage & recognize good ideas
- Appreciate honesty
- Let go of your ideas
- Try things & be open to new ideas

talking more than you're listening. I mean, it's very hard to learn some new ideas if all you're doing is talking. The second one is making instant judgments or forming instant opinions rather than try to sort of suspend your judgment and learn a bit more facts, get a little bit more information before you form an opinion. The third one is not acknowledging somebody who comes up with a great idea. So you should show that you're kind of actively listening and encouraging, and that you recognize when somebody contributes something useful.

EVE: Punishing honesty when it happens would have to be one.

PETER: Absolutely.

EVE: And I suppose the whole ego thing of being defensive about, that's my idea. I'm not letting go of it.

PETER: Absolutely, and look, to be honest with you, I've been collaborating with you for over 30 years. One of the things that I've always loved about working with you, is that you can have an idea, but if somebody presents a better idea, you lose your previous idea like that. You're not worried about ego, and you've got to hang onto it, and all that stuff. So that's a really important part of being able to collaborate with people.

EVE: It is, and it's a deal-breaker, I think.

PETER: Absolutely. The sixth collaboration killer is not experimenting, not trying things out, not being open to different ways of doing things or different ideas.

7:13

TITLE: **Improve Meeting Efficiency**

EVE: Well, ultimately, a lot of collaboration does go on in organizations. I mean, people are doing things in teams and there are meetings. In fact, (SUPER: **People are in meetings 15% of the time**) 15% of the time, apparently, from research, people are in meetings.

PETER: So we really need to look at how we can make them more efficient. First of all, you need to think about

GRAPHIC BUILDS:

Effective Meetings

- Determine who really needs to be at meeting
- Set agenda with time allocation
- Use appropriate tools and techniques

who really needs to be at the meeting, because often we have meetings and everyone gets invited, and it's just such a waste. Secondly, have an agenda for what items are going to be covered on that meeting. And allocate time for each of those agenda items. And finally, use the appropriate tools and techniques for your meeting. So for example, if you're trying to come up with new ideas, use brainstorming, that's a very effective tool.

EVE: Is there any new research about how meetings can achieve a better collaborative result?

PETER: Look, there is. We've all heard about emotional intelligence, but there's actually a new type of intelligence that people have called (SUPER: **Collective Intelligence**) collective intelligence, and there's some interesting research from MIT that shows that there are three factors that seem to predict collective intelligence. First of all,

GRAPHIC BUILDS:

Predicting Collective Intelligence

1. Group members effectively read emotional states
2. Equality of participation
3. Diversity
 - Higher % of women
 - Cognitive diversity

MIT Research

how effective group members are at kind of reading the emotional states of one another, so if somebody's frustrated, being able to read that and understand that. The second thing is the degree of equality of participation. And generally, we find that the more participation is spread, the better the collaboration, but this can mean that your meeting needs a trained facilitator. Now the third factor is diversity, and it's interesting that there's some research that shows that the higher percentage of women leads to a better collaborative outcome. But it's not just gender, it also is what we call cognitive diversity, and that is having people from different backgrounds in the group. They offer different perspectives and different points of view.

9:17

TITLE: **Design Collaborative Workplaces**

EVE: Why is it important to design collaborative workspaces?

PETER: Well, when you think about it, the physical layout of an office really contributes a lot to the vibe, and so that's an important part of trying to develop collaboration. For a long time, the open plan office was the way to go, but in fact what they found was that there were a number of problems with the open plan office that led to quite an increase in absenteeism. It seems to me there's a new paradigm that seems to be emerging, and this involves the creation of what are called (SUPER BUILDS: **Hybrid spaces – public and private areas**) hybrid spaces. So these include some public area, which is called a kind of an overlap zone, which encourages people to bump into one another and have those kind of random conversations, but then there are also some private spaces where people can have a bit of privacy, it's quiet, they're not going to get interrupted, and they can work on their own.

EVE: I've seen some really interesting developments where café-like areas are built into the workspace, or whiteboards or glass panels are around pillars where people can stop and start making notes, and have a discussion in the middle of a corridor.

PETER: That's right.

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